

A Guide To Feedback

Designers help turn the message and goals of their collaborators into easy-to-understand and captivating works of art. But, it often takes several rounds of design feedback before we can reach that final product.

Just as receiving design feedback can be a challenge for the designers, so too can giving it for their counterparts (sales reps and organizational leaders, etc.) Communicating feedback and revisions effectively and clearly can make or break a project.

The goal of this document is to establish consistent guidelines for effectively giving and receiving feedback on design, as well as reviewing and approving design as a group to insure this collaboration work as smoothly as possible.

Demystifying design

By sharing the way we approach problems as designers, we can create a common language with non-designers to discuss the different aspects of a design. The more design lingo you can familiarize yourself with, the greater likelihood of being able to give specific, actionable feedback to me.

Hue, Tint, Tone and Shade: All related to changes made to colors, hue is a base color. To request the designer try a different tint is to add white, a tone is to add gray and a shade is to add black.

Gradient: The gradual shift from one color to another.

Opacity: The transparency of the image. The lower an object's opacity, the more see-through it is.

Kerning and Tracking: Kerning is the spacing between individual letters, while tracking is a uniform amount of space between each character in a word.

Serif fonts have small lines and hooks at the end of their strokes, while sans-serif fonts do not.



White space: Also known as negative space. it's the amount of empty or unoccupied space in a design.

While these are just a handful of terms that can be helpful when delivering feedback, there are mountains more.

Drawing inspiration

If you like the way another brand looks, it's ok to show it as a reference but know that we can't straight up copy it. Not only is it not helpful to say something like "make it look like Apple", Apple's style might not even be a good solution for your brand within your market for your audience.

Instead of asking to copy it, think of why you like a certain look. Is it clean typography? Is it a simple color palette contrasted with sharp imagery? Is it some cool scrolling effects you saw on their socials? Once we understand what you like about another brand's identity, then we can try to work that into our designs.

"Opt for less cooks in the kitchen when giving design feedback. Having too many people involved in the review process can muddle the overall goal and slow down the project. Align with your team before presenting your initial reactions"

— Sadie Prouty

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Sandwich technique

“I love what you did with this color palette, it’s so warm and inviting, I’m not sure the value prop is clear in this design. The background shapes are really neat.”

The sandwich technique can distract from fundamental or essential feedback and often makes the “positive feedback” come off as insincere. Now, this doesn’t mean you shouldn’t share positive feedback, that’s always welcome. Just make sure it’s delivered in a way that doesn’t distract from negative or constructive feedback.

“Don’t tell me problems, give me solutions”

When it comes to design feedback, that isn’t always applicable. As the person ultimately doing the work, the designer may not align with your solution or might not be able to deliver upon your solution.

Instead, a great method is to describe the problem. This helps the designer work with you on the solution.

For example : don’t just tell the designer the CTA can’t go at the bottom of the page. Explain that heatmap data suggests users don’t make it to the bottom of the page. In this case, the solution may not be to move the CTA, but rather to create more visual cues guiding users down the page.

“Even if you consider yourself a numbers person that doesn't know creative, the designer can translate your input, however abstract or jumbled, into effective content that says exactly what you wanted to say. Whatever emotions or instincts come up during the feedback process, verbalize them without hesitation.”

— Liza Shkurina

Describe your experience

Describing your reactions using objective language keeps personal preferences or biases in the background. The goal here is to help a designer understand how you’re experiencing a design, so they can assess whether that aligns with the experience they’re trying to create.

Using this tactic, great feedback sounds something like: “The red delete button was the first thing that grabbed my attention, but as I studied the page more I realized the warning copy was the most useful element to me.” Sometimes it’s enough to say “I can’t articulate the ‘why’ behind my reactions to the design yet.” That leaves space for you to contemplate your initial reactions and transform them later into feedback that will help improve the work.

Meet me where I am

When delivering design feedback, knowing the reasoning behind creative decisions can make you see the work in a more profound way. Ask the designer to explain their rationale behind their decisions, this also gives them a greater opportunity to pitch their design. It’s often more productive to constructively disagree about the rationale behind a design decision.

If a designer is still working on designing the structural aspects of a feature or product, then giving feedback on type sizing or button colors will pull them up into a different layer of design that’s outside their current focus. It’s easy to align your

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feedback with where a designer is at in their process by asking: “Where are you looking for feedback right now?” or “What were other options you considered, and why did you choose this one?”

Let the designer be the designer

“Change the color to blue. No, lighter blue. Now move it down 10px.» You just turned the designer into a pixel pusher robot with little interest in their work.

You’ve just inherited all of the design decisions yourself. If you’ve given someone the responsibility of designing an experience, let them take responsibility and have the freedom to make their own decisions and work through the problems themselves.

“Design is a plan for arranging elements to accomplish a particular purpose.”
— Charles Eames

Arranging elements is not just about innate talent, but also about a consistent design process. Like engineers, architects, and other creative disciplines, designers use process as a way to consistently frame problems and create solutions.

Changing content post-design

Oftentimes, designers conceptualize and create visuals or layouts around already existing or finalized copy. Dramatically changing copy or other content after designs have been finalized and approved can have a significant impact on the layout or look and feel of that design, requiring more changes and thus, more feedback.

Dedicate time

Don’t do flybys. If you don’t have time to sit down, understand the problem and really give your full attention to the designer, then come back later when you have time or schedule a time to work through it with them.

Question to guide you

1. What is the objective of this design?
2. What elements of this design are related to the objective?
3. Are those elements effective in achieving the objective?
4. Why or why not?

Inviting non-designers into a more inclusive conversation around our work is one of the best ways to make our designs better. Improving the quality of feedback, makes it easier for us to ship great work that everyone feels confident in.

